

KANT'S ARGUMENT FOR THE DEPENDENCE OF THE COSMOLOGICAL PROOF ON THE ONTOLOGICAL PROOF

Arthur Henrique Soares dos Santos (UFPA)

santosarthursoares@gmail.com

1 – INTRODUCTION

The cosmological argument seeks to prove the existence of God “from an experience in general” (KrV, B 633). In this respect, it differs from the physico-theological proof, which begins from “a determinate experience, that of the things in the present world, their constitution and order” (KrV, B 648). The argument also differs from the ontological proof, since the ontological proof is entirely a priori, whereas the cosmological proof begins from possible experience (KrV, B 633).

Kant's principal objection to this argument is the thesis that the cosmological argument depends on the ontological argument and that, once the ontological argument fails, the cosmological argument fails as well. Thus, Kant defends the following claim: the cosmological argument is possible if and only if the ontological argument is possible. Accordingly, the aim of this paper is to assess Kant's thesis that the cosmological proof depends on the ontological proof.

Some qualifications are necessary. First, I do not intend to discuss the ontological proof, since I want to assess only the thesis that the cosmological argument depends on the ontological argument. Second, in this paper I consider only deductive versions of the cosmological argument. Thus, nothing I say here should be taken as supporting or opposing inductive versions of the cosmological argument, such as Richard Swinburne's (2004); I restrict the discussion here to deductive cosmological proofs.

2 – THE COSMOLOGICAL ARGUMENT

Kant focuses on Leibniz's version of this proof, which is based on the principle of sufficient reason (Craig, 1980, p. 283). Despite his focus on the Leibnizian argument, Kant understands his description and subsequent criticism to apply to all other versions. He “divides the cosmological proof into two stages, the first establishing the existence of a necessary being and the second demonstrating that this being is an *ens realissimum*” (Wood, 1978, pp. 123–124). According to

Kant, the cosmological proof says: “If something exists, then an absolutely necessary being also has to exist. Now I myself, at least, exist; therefore, an absolutely necessary being exists” (KrV, B 632). The same description is given by Kant in the *Lectures* (AK XXVIII, 1029). He further describes this inference in logical terms: “The minor premise contains an experience, the major premise an inference from an experience in general to the existence of something necessary.” (KrV, B 632–633)

Thus, the major premise describes how to infer the existence of an absolutely necessary being, whereas the minor premise introduces some experience in order to make possible the inference to the existence of the necessary being. The argument can be put into canonical form as follows:

(CK1) If something exists, then an absolutely necessary being exists.

(CK2) If I exist, then something exists.

(CK3) I exist.

(CK4) Something exists. [from (CK2) and (CK3)]

(CK5) Therefore, an absolutely necessary being exists. [from (CK1) and (CK4)]

The first step of the argument runs from premises (CK1) through (CK5). It should be noted that this part of the cosmological proof has not been formulated exactly as Kant formulates it. This is because, in Kant’s explanation, there is no explicit premise stating that, if I exist, then we know that something exists. Although this is an obvious truth, the premises must be made explicit in order to guarantee the logical validity of the argument. That said, premise (CK1) is stated explicitly by Kant at the beginning of the passage quoted above. Premise (CK2), by contrast, is an implicit premise in the reasoning described by Kant; it is not stated explicitly, but it is necessary to establish the correct logical connection between the first premise and the conclusion. Premise (CK3) is also stated explicitly by Kant. (CK4) is likewise an implicit premise, but it is logically necessary for deriving the conclusion; moreover, (CK4) results from a modus ponens inference from (CK2) and (CK3), and is rationally justified if those two premises are themselves rationally justified. Finally, the *modus ponens* inference from (CK1) and (CK4) yields the result sought by the defender of the cosmological argument: conclusion (CK5), that an absolutely necessary being exists.

This part, however, is only the first step of the cosmological argument, as Wood (1978, pp. 123-124) reminds us. After all, the second step is to demonstrate that the necessary being required by the cosmological proof is the *ens realissimum* identified as God. This inference proceeds by means of a transition from the idea of the necessary being to the idea of the *ens realissimum*, which would be the only way in which the necessary being could be thought. On the basis of KrV, B 633-634, the second part of the argument can be formalized as follows:

(CK6) An absolutely necessary being is a being determined *a priori*.

(CK7) The only being determined *a priori* is the *ens realissimum*.

(CK8) Therefore, an absolutely necessary being is the *ens realissimum*. [from (CK6) and (CK7)]

(CK9) If an absolutely necessary being exists, then an *ens realissimum* exists.

(CK10) Therefore, an *ens realissimum* exists. [from (CK9) and (CK5)]

Kant does not show how the defender of the cosmological argument intends to justify these premises. The basic idea, however, is that proponents of the cosmological proof are committed to the claim that any absolutely necessary being is the most real being [*ens realissimum*] (Byrne, 2007, p. 32). And this is precisely the core of the cosmological argument's theistic inference, which, according to Wood (1978, pp. 123-124), constitutes its second step.

3 – KANT'S ARGUMENT FOR THE DEPENDENCE OF THE COSMOLOGICAL PROOF ON THE ONTOLOGICAL PROOF

Kant raises five objections to the cosmological argument: (1) the inference from the contingent to a cause has no meaning outside the experience (KrV, B 637); (2) the cosmological argument confuses logical possibility with transcendental possibility (KrV, B 638); (3) it is illegitimate to infer a first cause from the impossibility of an infinite series of causes (KrV, B 638); (4) reason falsely satisfies itself when it completes the causal series with a first cause (KrV, B 638); and (5) the possibility of the cosmological argument depends on the ontological argument and, since the latter does not work, the former fails as well (KrV, B 635). The fifth and final objection is Kant's major objection to the cosmological argument: the claim that the cosmological proof

depends on the ontological proof. Kant presents this idea immediately after describing the cosmological proof.

Kant makes two important points (KrV, B 634-635). The first is the idea that the empirical argument cannot establish the properties of the necessary being. The second important point is Kant's basic thesis: it is presupposed that the theistic concept of the *ens realissimum* satisfies the concept of a necessary being, so that the former is inferred from the latter; however, this is a proposition defended by the ontological argument, and it thereby becomes the foundation on which the cosmological argument depends. This is the thesis that the cosmological argument depends on the ontological argument (Valicella, 2000, p. 441; Byrne, 2007, p. 32).

If this dependence thesis is correct, then one can say that "it is really only the ontological proof from mere concepts that contains all the force of proof in the so-called cosmological proof" (KrV, B 635). This amounts to the following claim: the cosmological argument is possible if and only if the ontological argument is possible. Given that the cosmological proof, as Kant understands it, has two stages, it should be recognized that this objection is directed against the second stage (identifying the necessary being with the *ens realissimum*), and not against the first (the argument for the necessary being). Kant does not agree with the first stage either, since objections 1, 2, and 3 are directed precisely against this first stage. In this particular objection, however, Kant accepts the first step for the sake of argument in order to focus on the second (Wood, 1978, p. 124).

With these considerations in place, the first part of Kant's defense of the thesis that the cosmological argument depends on the ontological argument can be understood. He says:

If the proposition is correct: 'Every absolutely necessary being is at the same time the most real being' (which is the *nervus probandi* of the cosmological proof), then like any affirmative judgment, it must be convertible *per accidens*, thus: 'Some most real beings are at the same time absolutely necessary beings.' But now one *ens realissimum* does not differ the least bit from another, and thus what holds of some beings contained under this concept holds also of all. Hence I will also (in this case) be able to convert the proposition absolutely, i.e., 'Every most real being is a necessary being'. (KrV, B 636)

Kant's inferences can be described more clearly in light of the square of opposition. Although Kant uses a more simplified description, detailing the logical basis of each inference may be important for seeing the logical validity of his objection. Proposition *p*, *that every absolutely*

necessary being is at the same time the most real being, is a universal affirmative proposition. On the basis of classical logic, Kant knew very well that every universal affirmative proposition entails a particular affirmative proposition. Thus, he can arrive at proposition *q*, that *some absolutely necessary beings are most real beings*, which is subordinate to the first. Proposition *q* is equivalent to proposition *r*, that *some most real beings are absolutely necessary beings*. Let ‘Nx’ abbreviate ‘x is an absolutely necessary being’ and ‘Rx’ abbreviate ‘x is an *ens realissimum*’. We can represent this as follows:

p: $\forall x [Nx \rightarrow Rx]$ ¹

This universal affirmative proposition entails the subordinate particular affirmative:

q: $\exists x [Nx \& Rx]$ ²

Proposition *q* is not yet the proposition Kant wants, since he aims to reverse the order of ‘Nx’ and ‘Rx’. However, it is easy to arrive at proposition *r*, which is logically equivalent to *q*:

r: $\exists x [Rx \& Nx]$ ³

From a logical point of view, these inferences performed by Kant are perfectly valid. Kant then introduces a new proposition: an *ens realissimum* is not distinct from another *ens realissimum*; after all, if the concept of the *ens realissimum* is that which unites all perfections, there is no distinction between an *ens realissimum* and another. This entails that if some *ens realissimum* is an absolutely necessary being, then every *ens realissimum* is a necessary being. It is important to note that Kant does not commit the logical error of claiming that, if a particular proposition is true, then its universal counterpart is also true. His inference from the particular to the universal is grounded on the proposition that, since the *ens realissimum* is a being containing all perfections, whatever holds of some *ens realissimum* holds of every *ens realissimum*. Consequently, Kant

¹ For every x, if x is an absolutely necessary being, then x is an *ens realissimum*.

² There is an x such that x is an absolutely necessary being and x is an *ens realissimum*.

³ There is an x such that x is an *ens realissimum* and an absolutely necessary being/

commits no logical errors in this objection. The result is a new universal affirmative proposition *s*: every most real being is an absolutely necessary being. Formally:

s: $\forall x [Rx \rightarrow Nx]$ ⁴

This is the proposition that Kant wanted to reach. To understand why, one must remember that the second part of the cosmological argument as Kant describes it ends with conclusion (CK8), that an absolutely necessary being is the *ens realissimum*, which is identical to proposition *p* discussed in the preceding paragraphs. Kant attempted to show that this proposition could be converted absolutely into proposition *s*, that every *ens realissimum* is an absolutely necessary being. This result is important for the thesis that the cosmological argument depends on the ontological argument for the following reason: “Now because this proposition is determined merely from its concepts a priori, the mere concept of the most real being must also carry with it the absolute necessity of this being – which is just what the ontological proof asserts and the cosmological proof does not want to recognize, despite the fact that it underlies its inferences, though in a covert way.” (KrV, B 636–637)

The central idea of this passage is that proposition *s*, that every most real being is an absolutely necessary being, commits the cosmological proof to the ontological proof. This can be clarified as follows. Kant maintains that proposition (CK8) of the cosmological argument, that an absolutely necessary being is the *ens realissimum*, logically entails proposition *s*, as seen above. However, proposition *s* is a premise of the ontological argument which, if that argument were successful, would entail the existence of the *ens realissimum*, since it would be a necessary being. But this procedure is entirely *a priori* and is exactly the procedure employed by the ontological proof. As Valicella puts it, in the cosmological argument, the existence of the most real being follows from its concept, which is exactly what the ontological argument entails (2000, p. 444). This means that the cosmological argument depends on the ontological argument (KrV, B 635). Consequently, we can arrive at the claim that the cosmological argument is possible if and only if the ontological argument is possible.

4 – CONCLUDING REMARKS

⁴ For every *x*, if *x* is an *ens realissimum*, then *x* is an absolutely necessary being.

In summary, I conclude that Kant offers a good argument for the dependence of the cosmological proof on the ontological proof (at least with respect to deductive versions of the cosmological argument). The second stage of the cosmological argument – defending the claim that the necessary being is the theistic *ens realissimum* – operates at a wholly *a priori* level, just as the ontological argument does.

REFERENCES

- BYRNE, Peter. *Kant on God*. London: Ashgate Publishing, 2007.
- CRAIG, William Lane. *The Cosmological Argument from Plato to Leibniz*. London: MacMillan, 1980.
- KANT, Immanuel. *Critique of Pure Reason*. Trans. Norman Kemp Smith. London: Macmillan, 1929.
- KANT, Immanuel. *Critique of Pure Reason*. Trans. Paul Guyer e Allen Wood. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1998. KANT, Immanuel. Lectures on the philosophical doctrine of religion (1817). In: Wood, Allen; DI GIOVANNI, George (eds). *Religion and Rational Theology*. The Cambridge Edition of the Works of Immanuel Kant. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press; 1996, pp. 335-452.
- OPPY, Graham. Cosmological Arguments. *Noûs*, v. 43, n. 1, p. 31-48, 2009. Disponível em: <https://www.jstor.org/stable/40267327>.
- TOOLEY, Michael. Does the Cosmological Argument Entail the Ontological Argument? *The Monist*, v. 54, n. 3, 416-426, 1970. Disponível em: <http://www.jstor.org/stable/27902187>.
- VALICELLA, William F. Does the Cosmological Argument Depend on the Ontological? *Faith and Philosophy*, v. 17, n. 4, p. 441-458, 2000. Disponível em: <https://place.asburyseminary.edu/faithandphilosophy/vol17/iss4/2/>.
- SANTOS, Arthur Henrique Soares dos. *Kant e a Teologia Natural*. São Paulo: Editora Dialética, 2026.
- SWINBURNE, Richard. *The Existence of God*. 2nd ed. Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2004.
- WOOD, Allen. *Kant's Rational Theology*. New York: Cornell University Press, 1978.